ing second fiddle...the balance of power has tilted in our favour."

Within the BJP, the vote was overwhelmingly in favour of Devendra Fadnavis, the man who crafted his party's strategic thrust. To him went the credit of effecting the rapprochement between Nagpur and New Delhi, upset as they were with the decision to ally with traditional foe NCP. He has been chief minister before, for a full five-year term from 2014 onward, and for five days in 2019. Coalition dharma denied him a third shot when Shinde walked out of the Uddhav government to the BJP side in return for the chief ministership. But the question of who will be chief minister this time was still being deliberated upon till the time of going to press.

The New Power Equations

Chief ministership is not the only issue for the triumphant BJP to resolve. The party also has to work out the nitty-gritty of the power-sharing arrangement, especially regarding crucial portfolios like home, finance, urban development and rural development. The interests of both Shinde and Ajit Pawar will have to be taken into account. Shinde may have made a tactical retreat, but he certainly won't be disappearing. In the two and a half years that he was chief minister, he had managed to resist the BJP's attempts at backseat driving, putting his foot down on matters of policy as well as in appointments and transfers of officials. Also, as these results show, he has outgrown the Thackerays' shadow. And though the idea was borrowed from the BJP scheme in Madhya Pradesh, both he and Ajit Pawar claimed credit for the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana, Shinde for its implementation, Ajit for announcing it in the budget. Shinde's Maratha credentials also went some way in assuaging his caste cohort. Also, unlike predecessor Uddhav, Shinde projected himself as a man of the masses, one who rose from a humble autorickshaw-wallah to occupy the highest office in the state. The CM, he is wont to say, stands for 'common man', not 'chief minister'.

TO BRASS TACKS

WHAT WORKED FOR THE MAHAYUTI

- Revdi politics, especially the flagship Ladki Bahin scheme
- OBC counter-mobilisation against Maratha hegemony
- Majoritarian assertion with slogans like 'Batenge to katenge' and 'vote jihad'
- Micro-management by BJP and Sangh Parivar cadre
- Early announcement of candidates

CHALLENGES BEFORE THE MAHAYUTI

- Balancing politically-beneficial 'laabhaarthi' politics with development of state
- Changing power equations in BJP's favour without antagonising Shiv Sena or NCP
- Ensuring issues like agrarian distress and caste conflicts do not come to a head
- Meeting expectations of leaders and legislators for cabinet berths and sinecures
- Ensuring their brute majority does not lull them into making political blunders



MANDAR DEODHAR

WHAT WENT WRONG FOR THE MVA

- Over-reliance on the sympathy factor
- Inability to counter BJP's polarising agenda or its welfare schemes like Ladki Bahin
- Failure to tap into agrarian distress, Maratha disenchantment or bread and butter issues like lack of jobs, flight of projects from Maharashtra to Gujarat, etc.
- Public squabbling between leaders of the MVA
- Over-confidence post LS results and wrong selection of seats and candidates

Shinde may have made a tactical retreat, but the BJP can't afford a further rise in his fortunes. It cannot demolish one Uddhav to replace him with another